

On Theology's Concept of Nature

with Special Reference to

Malebranche: *De la recherche de la vérité*

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Between theology and natural science there is no understanding; theology's concept of nature is not natural, and natural science's is not theological.

Even by merely confining oneself to a factual juxtaposition of those natural events in whose interpretation natural science most decidedly contradicts theology, it would be easy to make the disagreement between the two sciences conspicuous. Touch whichever dogma, whichever theological presupposition one will; insofar as there can in any way be a question of a real, corresponding natural relation, natural science, by virtue of the investigation of the facts, must reject the theological explanation.

Is it the creation in six days: natural science proves that for the formation of the earth alone a period of more than 6×6 million years must have elapsed.

Is it the dogma of Paradise and the Fall: natural science proves that there was corruptibility, pain, and death in the world long before the first human beings came to be.

Is the talk of the Flood and Noah's Ark: natural science proves that "the Flood" is a natural local catastrophe, and that the animals could not possibly have been saved in Noah's Ark, since the beasts of prey would in a few days have devoured the other animals, and thereafter have died of hunger.

Thus one could go on, and still not reach the goal. Even if the juxtaposition were carried through ever so completely, the grounds and counter-grounds from both sides

sought out and weighed ever so carefully, it would nevertheless along this path hardly be possible to arrive at any decisive result.

To be sure, natural science, with respect to the main points of the matter, is on the whole in agreement with itself, just as theology too must on the whole be said to follow a direction answering to its own peculiar endeavours; but one may not on that account suppose that either of the two sciences would at a given time be wholly and entirely in agreement with itself in the interpretation of particulars.

Natural science is, as they say, in becoming; this becoming — under which, as regards particulars, it continually corrects itself, secures its method, purifies and broadens its foundation — is precisely characteristic of its luxuriant growth, its restless, imposing progress.

Theology, then, is in its own way also in becoming — a becoming, namely, under which its ever-increasing lack of principle and the inward discord of its members point more or less toward the weakness of old age and impending dissolution¹.

If both sciences are now thus each in its own becoming, then it would surely help but little for anyone to begin afresh either to weigh the grounds for and against “the Flood,” or to debate the problem of “Noah’s Ark,” or, in other words, to set natural science’s conception of particular phenomena against theology’s particular dogmas.

If an understanding between theology and natural science is to be thought possible, it must presumably begin with the two sciences coming to agreement in the determination of that concept which, for the scientific reality of both, is a decisive fundamental concept, namely the concept: *nature*.

By such a determination of the concept one cannot here first of all think of some definition in general; for with formal definitions little is accomplished in natural science. The task is to indicate the point of view under which the essence of nature can be seen in the purest, truest scientific light.

Relying on the testimony of the senses and the validity of thought, natural science begins by taking existing things as they are given, then advances by exact examination from the known to the as-yet-unknown, and everywhere confines itself to seeing nature in nature’s light.

Theology, on the other hand, chooses for itself a higher point of departure. Beginning with the Creator, it passes through creation over to the creature, and so comes, by its

¹Lest it should seem to some reader less acquainted with the discussions belonging here as though this assertion were thrown out without any foundation, I must for the present refer to my work *Evangelitroen og Theologien*. I may do so with all the more right, since no theologian yet, so far as is known to me, has found himself moved to show the groundlessness of the view set forth in the said work.

own opinion, to behold nature as God's work in God's light.

If it now really is the case that there truly exists a science able to present nature in God's light, and if this science is theology: then indeed the theological concept of nature, whatever may be said for or against the interpretation of any single phenomenon, is undeniably the highest norm by which empirical science, in its judgment of the essence of nature, has to direct itself.

But should it, on the other hand, prove scientifically demonstrable that there neither is nor can be a science able in any way, in any degree, to elucidate the natural by means of the supernatural: might we not then conclude from this that the theological doctrine of creation, with its corresponding explanation of nature, had best be assigned a place of its own outside of science?

As a representative of the theological conception of the essence of nature, we choose, for the clarification of the matter, a keen thinker, the author of the work *De la Recherche de la Vérité*², the noble Malebranche.

That Malebranche is a Catholic, and that his Cartesian natural philosophy has long since been antiquated, is of no significance in this connection.

Here, as regards the dogmas, there is only one dogma on which it essentially depends; it is the dogma of creation. Here, as regards natural science, there is only one task on which attention is fixed; it is the task of recognizing nature as God's work, of beholding all things in God.

Inwardly convinced that this great task can be solved, M. is so far from withdrawing into the mysterious, and concealing poverty of thought in aesthetically nebulous speculations, that he rather calls for beginning with the particular, the distinct, the easily comprehensible, and in many places speaks a language such that one would believe it was not one of the Fathers of the Oratory speaking of God's omnipotence, but one of today's naturalists dismissing philosophical mysticism³.

²Paris MDCLXXVIII.

³Jfr. t. Ex. De l. Recherch. S. 394. Combien de gens rejettent la Philosophie de M. Descartes par cette plaisante raison que les principes en sont trop simples et trop faciles. Il n'y a point de termes obscurs et mystérieux dans cette Philosophie: des femmes et des personnes qui ne savent ni grec ni latin, sont capables de l'apprendre: il faut donc que soit peu de chose, et il n'est pas juste que de grands génies s'y appliquent. Ils s'imaginent que des principes si clairs et si simples ne sont pas assez féconds, pour expliquer les effets de la nature qu'ils supposent obscure et embarrassée. ... Ils aiment donc mieux expliquer des effets, dont ils ne comprennent point la cause, par des principes qu'ils ne conçoivent point, et qu'il est absolument impossible de concevoir, que par des principes simples et intelligibles tout-ensemble. Car ces Philosophes expliquent des choses obscures par des principes qui ne sont pas seulement obscurs, mais entièrement incompréhensibles.

"It is" — so thinks Malebranche — "error that is the cause of man's misery; it is therefore necessary that it be combated with all one's powers. One must not imagine that it is so troublesome to seek the truth. One need only open one's eyes, be attentive, and follow a few rules which we shall give in what follows. For it is, after all, sharp thinking that brings light and discovers the truth."

"Although our senses are corrupted by sin, it is nevertheless not really the senses, but our freedom, that is the cause of our errors."

"For since we are composed of mind and body (Etant composez d'un esprit et d'un corps), we have two kinds of goods to seek, the mind's and the body's. We have then also two ways in which we can know whether something is good or evil. We can know a good either by a clear insight or by an obscure sensation (un sentiment confus). I recognize by reason that justice is lovable; I also know by taste that this or that fruit is good. The beauty of justice cannot be sensed (ne se sent pas), the goodness of the fruit cannot be thought (ne se connoit pas). The goods of the body therefore do not deserve that a mind, which God has created only for himself, should scrutinize them; it is therefore necessary that the mind, without further examination (examen), be able to know such goods by the short, indubitable test of sensation⁴."

"If the mind saw in bodies only what is really in them, then it could not love them, and could not make use of them without much reluctance; it is therefore necessary that they seem agreeable, in that they occasion feelings that do not pertain to their essence."

"But it is not so with God, who alone is the mind's true good; for him it is not enough to be loved with the blind love of instinct; he wills to be loved with an enlightened, clear, and resolved love (d'un amour éclairé et d'un amour déchoix)."

"To understand this rightly, one must know that there is a very considerable difference between the way in which the Author of Nature (l'Auteur de la Nature) moves matter, and the way in which he without ceasing moves the mind toward the good in general (vers le bien en general). For matter is without any activity, without power to arrest its motion or determine its direction."

"It is otherwise with the will; of it one can nevertheless in a certain sense (en un sens) say that it is active, and that it has in itself the power to take up the impression (impression) God gives it⁵ in various ways, and thereby to occasion all the disorder (dérèglement) that shows itself in the inclinations, and all the miseries that are consequences

⁴S. 18. Les pierres ne sont pas propres à la nourriture, la preuve en est convaincante, et le seul goût en a fait tomber d'accord tous les hommes.

⁵S. 5. car quoi qu' elle ne puisse pas arrêter cette impression, elle peut en un sens la détourner du côté qu'il lui plaît...

of sin.”

“Even if the will is not free in the sense that it should have the power to will and not to will, it is nevertheless able to drive us forward toward the good in general⁶.”

“Since the will always directs itself according to the representation of the good, and we cannot possibly will that which at the same moment we must regard as an essential evil, there must be the most intimate connection between cognition and will, between the true and the good⁷.”

“The senses and passions (les sens et les passions) do not have their origin from sin, but the power with which they tyrannize sinners does. This power is not so much a disturbance on the side of the senses as a confusion in man’s mind and will.”

“Adam, in his state of innocence, had the same senses as we, but was the unconditional master of the impressions of joy and pain that they awakened in his body. Only when he voluntarily turned away from the countenance of God, as it were to sate his mind with the beauty and anticipated sweetness of the forbidden fruit, did his senses and passions rebel against him, and make him, like us, a slave of all sensuous things.”

“Our senses are not so corrupted as one imagines; but it is the innermost of our soul, it is our freedom, that is corrupted. It is not our senses that deceive us; it is our will that deceives us by its rash judgments.”

“When one, for example, sees light, then it is quite certain that one sees light; when one feels warmth, one does not deceive oneself in believing that one feels it — be it before or after the Fall.”

“But one deceives oneself when one assumes (quand on juge) that the warmth one feels is outside the soul that feels it. It is a rash judgment, resting on the misuse of freedom. Therefore we ought carefully to observe the rule never to judge by the senses what things are in themselves; for the senses are in reality not given that we should know the truth of things in themselves, but only to preserve our body (pour la conservation de notre corps).”

“The ground of error also does not lie in the limitation of our understanding; for the understanding is indeed limited, but it is nevertheless the will that guides our power of judgment⁸. It therefore becomes a task of the will to work its way out of the illusion and seek the truth. But to seek the truth is in all things to seek God.”

⁶S. 5. ... par ce mot de *Volonté*, je prétens ici désigner l’impression ou le mouvement naturel, qui nous porte vers le bien indéterminé et en général: et par celui de *Liberté*, je n’entens autre chose que la force qu’ a l’esprit de détourner cette impression vers les objets, qui nous plaisent.

⁷S. 6. C’est à-peu-près la même chose de la connoissance de la vérité que de l’amour du bien.

⁸S. 6 ... nous sommes aussi libres dans nos faux jugemens, que dans nos amours déreglez...

“Truth is known by its clarity, by its self-evidence⁹; it must therefore be impressed upon us that we never grant anything before it is so evident to us that we are as it were compelled by the inner, earnest correction of our reason (jusqu’à ce que nous y soyons comme forcez par des reproches intérieures de notre raison¹⁰).”

After thus having pointed out the cause of error, and having besides (in the first and second Books) treated in detail the errors occasioned by the senses and the imagination, the author passes over (in the third Book) to treat of the essence of the mind: *De l’entendement ou de l’esprit pur*.

The general relation between mind and matter has already, in the first Book, been conceived in the following way:

“Just as matter, the extended, has a twofold capacity — a capacity to receive different form, and a capacity to be moved — so too the human mind has two faculties, *the understanding* (l’entendement), by which we apprehend different ideas, that is: bring different things to consciousness, and *the will* (la volonté), the capacity for manifold inclinations, or the willing of different things.”

This juxtaposition of the material and the mental, whereby apparent points of resemblance are brought out, must not, however, be understood as though a natural kinship between mind and matter were here presupposed. On the contrary! It is impressed throughout the whole investigation, from first to last, that the two substances are as heterogeneous as possible.

Although different faculties are ascribed to them, they nevertheless have no active faculties¹¹. The concept “faculty” must here, for the mind as well as for matter, be taken in so passive a sense that it does not at all express a capacity for reciprocal activity, but only a possibility of being acted upon by God¹².

“The essence of the mind,” it now says (third Book), “consists in thinking alone, just as that of matter in extension alone. It is in accordance with the different modifications of thinking that the mind is now willing, now representing, or has several other peculiar

⁹S. 9. Car la vérité ne se trouve presque jamais qu’ avec l’évidence, et l’évidence ne consiste que dans la vûe claire et distincte de toutes les parties et de tous les rapports de l’objet, qui sont nécessaires pour porter un jugement assuré.

¹⁰S. 1–2. L’exactitude de l’esprit n’a presque rien de pénible: ce n’est point une servitude comme l’imagination la représente; et si nous y trouvons d’abord quelque difficulté, nous en recevons bientôt des satisfactions qui nous récompensent bien de nos peines; car enfin il n’y a qu’elle qui produise la lumière, et qui découvre la vérité.

¹¹S. 4. C’est pour nous accommoder à la manière ordinaire de parler, que nous dirons dans la suite, que les sens sentent...

¹²S. 5. De même que l’Auteur de la Nature est la cause universelle de tous les mouvemens, qui se trouvent dans la matière; c’est aussi lui qui est la cause générale de toutes les inclinations naturelles qui se trouvent dans les esprits...

forms.”

“It likewise depends on different modifications, namely of extension, that matter is now water, now wood, now fire, or has an infinity of other such forms¹³.”

Since now the essence of the mind is placed in thought, it might indeed seem as though on the whole too strong an emphasis were here laid on the will; but M. expressly remarks that the faculty of willing is nevertheless inseparable from the mind, although it does not constitute its essence, just as the faculty of being moved is inseparable from matter, although it likewise does not constitute matter's essence.

“Even if thinking is the essence of the mind, we may nevertheless by no means conclude from this that the thinking mind should be able of itself to know all the modifications whose possibility it contains¹⁴.”

“When our soul here below receives only very few modifications, it is because it is bound to a body and dependent on it.”

“The matter of which our body is composed is able to receive only very few modifications, as long as we live. This matter cannot dissolve into earth, into vapour, until after our death. During our lifetime it cannot become air, fire, diamond, metal; it cannot become round, square, triangular: it must be flesh, and have a human figure, in order that our soul may be united with it.”

“It is the same with the soul. It is necessary that it have sensations of warmth, of cold, of colour, of light, of tones, of smell, of taste, and many other modifications. These sensations teach it precisely to preserve its machine (*l'appliquent à la conservation de sa machine*¹⁵).”

“Let one beware of dispersing the mind by wanting to explain things that are far too intricate. For the human mind is subject to errors, not only because it is not infinite,

¹³S. 171. Je ne croi pas aussi qu'il soit possible de concevoir un esprit qui ne pense point, quoi qu'il soit fort facile d'en concevoir un qui ne sente point, qui n'imagine point, et même qui ne veuille point: de même qu'il n'est pas possible de concevoir une matière, qui ne soit pas étendue quoi qu'il soit assez facile d'en concevoir une, qui ne soit ni terre, ni métal ni quarrée ni ronde et qui même ne soit point en mouvement. Il faut conclure de là, que comme il se peut faire qu'il y ait de la matière, qui ne soit ni terre ni métal, ni quarrée ni ronde ni même en mouvement: il se peut faire aussi qu'un esprit ne sente ni chaud ni froid, ni joie, ni tristesse, n'imagine rien, et même ne veuille rien; de sorte que toutes ces modifications ne lui sont point essentielles. *La pensée toute seule est donc l'essence de l'esprit, ainsi que l'étendue toute seule est l'essence de la matière.*

¹⁴S. 173. Un simple morceau de cire est donc capable d'un nombre infini, ou plutôt d'un nombre infiniment infini de différentes modifications, que nul esprit ne peut comprendre. Quelle raison donc de s'imaginer que l'âme qui est beaucoup plus noble que le corps, ne soit capable que des seules modifications qu'elle a déjà reçues.

¹⁵Elles l'agitent, et l'effraient dès que le moindre ressort se débande, ou se rompt, et ainsi il faut que l'âme y soit sujette, tant que son corps sera sujet à la corruption. Mais lorsqu'il sera revêtu de l'immortalité, et que nous ne craignons plus la dissolution de ses parties, il est raisonnable de croire qu'elle ne sera plus touchée de ces sensations incommodes que nous sentons malgré nous; mais d'une infinité d'autres toutes différentes, dont nous n'avons maintenant aucune idée.

but also because it does not have enough perseverance to dwell on each single object so long, until it has been in every respect completely and exactly investigated.”

“The objects with which the mind occupies itself can be divided into two classes: they are either in the soul or outside it.”

“Those that are in the soul are its own thoughts, by which are in general understood all the things (*toutes les choses!*) that cannot be in the soul without its becoming aware of them, such as: its own sensations, its imaginations, pure concepts and representations, even its passions (*ses passions mêmes*) and natural inclinations.”

As regards these objects, the soul can indeed know them without needing an intermediary; for they are nothing other than the soul itself, modified in this or that way (*d’une telle ou telle façon*); but *how does the soul come to the knowledge of the objects that are outside the soul?*

That is a chief question.

“We see the sun, the stars, an infinite multitude of objects outside us; yet it is not probable that the soul goes out of the body, that it, so to speak, takes a stroll through the heavens in order there to behold all these objects. Nor, then, does it see them by themselves. The mind’s immediate object, when it sees the sun, is not the sun itself, but a something that is intimately united with our soul, and it is this that I call the idea” (S. 188. *De la nature des idées*).

The characteristic feature of M.’s doctrine of ideas is now a direct consequence of the peculiar way in which he, in relation to the philosophical standpoint of the time, explains to himself the knowledge of external objects.

“Material objects cannot possibly be apprehended by themselves; they are apprehended only by the ideas corresponding to them in the soul: whence then come these ideas?”¹⁶

Toward an answer to this question M. makes his way through a critique of the theories diverging from his own view.

“The Peripatetics’ opinion, that external objects should send us their images (*des espèces, qui leur ressemblent*), and that these should then, through the outer senses, be brought to the common sense (*au sens commun*), is unreasonable; these impression-images (*especes impresses*) would then themselves have to be little bodies¹⁷, and these

¹⁶S. 190. Nous assurons donc qu’il est absolument nécessaire, que les idées, que nous avons des corps, et de tous les autres objets, que nous n’apercevons point par eux mêmes, viennent de ces mêmes corps ou de ces objets: ou bien que nôtre âme ait la puissance de produire ces idées: ou que Dieu les ait produites avec elle en la créant, ou qu’il les produise toutes les fois qu’on pense à quelque objet: ou que l’âme ait en elle-même toutes les perfections qu’elle voit dans ces corps: ou enfin qu’elle soit unie avec un être tout parfait, et qui renferme généralement toutes les perfections des êtres créés.

¹⁷S. 191. Tous les objets, comme le Soleil, les Etoiles, et tous ceux qui sont proche de nos yeux, ne peuvent pas envoyer des especes, qui soient d’autre nature qu’eux ... c’est pourquoi les Philosophes disent

bodies, with which space would be filled, would then, owing to the impenetrability of matter, have to crush and collide with one another, some going to one side, others to another, and thus could not make the objects visible.”

The opinion of those who assume that the ideas of objects are created with us, so that God does not need at each moment to awaken them in the soul when we have need of them, is refuted by the following consideration:

“We have, even as regards simple figures, an infinite multitude of ideas. Ellipses, triangles, polygons, and the like can, with respect to proportions of magnitude, be imagined in innumerable ways¹⁸. It is then highly improbable that God should have created such a swarm of ideas in and with the human mind. But suppose that we did have such a store of co-created ideas (*un magasin de toutes les idées*), it still remains wholly inexplicable how we come to apply the right idea when the corresponding object presents itself. We see, for example, the sun. The image that the sun imprints in the brain has, as already shown, no resemblance to the idea we form of the sun; nor does the soul notice the least thing of the impression the sun makes either on the ground of the eye or in the brain: it is therefore impossible to explain how, among the innumerable ideas, we come precisely to choose the idea of the sun when we see the sun.” “Those who maintain that our souls themselves have the faculty of being able to form ideas corresponding to the objects about which we would think, although the impressions coming from these objects are not images resembling the objects, have either far too poor conceptions of ideas or far too lofty thoughts of the human mind¹⁹.”

“Such an imagining of the soul’s perfection is presumptuous. God alone can in himself behold and know all things, since he is the Creator of all things. ‘Say not that you have the light in yourselves,’ says St. Augustine, ‘for God alone has the light in himself.’”

“There then remains only one view as the sole rational one (*qui paroît seule conforme à la raison*), namely, that minds have all their thoughts from God.”

“To grasp this rightly, we must first recall that God necessarily must have the ideas of all created things in himself, since otherwise he could not produce them; next, that God, by virtue of his omnipresence, is so intimately united with our souls that one could

ordinairement, que ces especes sont grossieres et matérielles, à la différence des especes *expresses*: (especes matérielles et sensibles, qui sont rendues intelligibles par l’intellect agent ou agissant, et sont propres pour être reçues dans l’intellect patient S. 190) qui sont spiritualisées.

¹⁸S. 196. L’esprit voit donc toutes ces choses: il en a des idées. Il est sûr que ces idées ne lui manqueront jamais, quand il emploieroit des siècles infinis à la considération même d’une seule figure.

¹⁹S. 193. En effet le monde intelligible doit être plus parfait que le monde matériel et terrestre... Ainsi, quand on assure, que les hommes ont la puissance de se former les idées telles qu’il leur plaît, on se met fort en danger d’assurer que les hommes ont la puissance de faire des êtres plus nobles et plus parfaits que le monde que Dieu a créé. On ne fait pas cependant réflexion à cela, parce qu’on s’imagine, qu’une idée n’est rien, à cause qu’elle ne se fait point sentir ...

even say that he is the place of minds ((qu'il est le lieu des esprits), just as one says of space that it is the place of bodies."

"Under these presuppositions it is therefore certain that the mind can see what it is in God that presents created things, since it is so spiritual, so intelligible, so present to the mind. The mind can then see in God God's work, so truly as God wills to reveal it to it." Thus M. comes to set up the principle so indispensable for theology, namely, that we behold all things in God:

Que nous voyons toutes choses en Dieu.

This fundamental proposition must not, however, be misunderstood as though the meaning were that we limited human beings, by seeing things in God, can now also see through God's essence²⁰. Far from it! How should the imperfect be able to grasp the perfect?

"One more reason for assuming that we see all things because God wills it is also this, that we thereby recognize our infinite dependence on God; for of ourselves we know nothing. Non sumus sufficientes cogitare aliquid a nobis, tanquam ex nobis, sed sufficientia nostra a Deo est. 2 Cor. 3, 5."

"It is God himself who enlightens the philosophers in those cognitions which these ungrateful people call natural, although they come to them from heaven. Deus enim illis manifestavit. Rom. 1, 19. It is he who is the mind's true light: Pater luminum. Jac. 1, 17. It is he who teaches men science: Qui docet hominem scientiam. Psalm. 94, 10. In a word: it is the true light which enlightens all those who come into this world: lux vera, quæ illuminat omnem hominem venientem in hunc mundum. Joh. 1, 9."

No one will be able to mistake that this is all theological, truly theological.

These features of a doctrine of knowledge untenable in itself can, however, in this connection interest us only insofar as they furnish the presuppositions for a corresponding view of nature, and thereby make evident what lies in theology's concept of nature, when the consequences contained in it are set forth as clearly, as many-sidedly, as unreservedly, as in Malebranche.

If God's revelation, continuing itself in the thinking minds, is the sole true source of knowledge, then it presumably follows of itself that the essence of things depends solely on the divine will, that nothing in nature has force and power to act of itself, but that it must be God, God alone, who works all in all things.

²⁰S. 200. Mais il faut bien remarquer, qu'on ne peut pas conclure que les esprits voyent l'essence de Dieu, de ce qu'ils voyent toutes choses en Dieu de cette manière. Parce que ce qu'ils voyent est très-imparfait, et que Dieu est très-parfait.

"Aristotle²¹ and the philosophers who follow his banner miss the truth and walk in darkness. Relying on sense-impressions, they give us only empty words and confused representations of things."

"All the categories (termes) that designate only sensuous representations are ambiguous — ambiguous, be it noted, through error and ignorance, and thus in turn the cause of an infinite multitude of errors."

"The word 'Ram,' for example, is ambiguous; it means a ruminant animal; it also means a constellation which the sun enters in spring. By such an expression, to be sure, no one is so easily deceived; for one would have to be an astrologer in the extreme to imagine that there could here be any real connection between Ram and Ram. But as regards the categories of sensuousness otherwise, one is easily deceived; for there is almost no one who notices that they are one and all ambiguous."

"When, for example, the philosophers say: fire is hot; the plant is green, sugar sweet, and so on, they understand it like children and everyday people, as though it were the fire that contained the heat they feel, the plant the colour they think they see, and the sugar the sweetness they taste when they eat it; and so with all things we see or sense. They do not say two words without saying something false: all that they say about this matter is obscure and confused."

This is then proved on various grounds:

"First, human beings are highly at variance about the sensuous impressions: what one finds sweet, another finds bitter; what one finds warm, another finds cold."

"Second, the most diverse objects can make the same sense-impression. Gypsum, snow, sugar, salt, and so on give the same sensation of colour: nevertheless the whiteness of these things is very different, if one will otherwise judge by something other than mere sensation. When one therefore says: the flour is white, one says nothing definite."

"Third, the corporeal properties that cause the most different sense-impressions are now and then almost the same, and, conversely, those that produce roughly the same impression are often very different. The qualities sweetness and bitterness are almost not different, but the sensations of sweetness and bitterness are essentially different. The motions (mouvements) that cause pain and tickling differ only by a more and a less, but the feelings of tickling and pain are essentially different."

"Another series of ambiguous expressions is drawn from logic, by whose general

²¹S. 383. Car les termes ordinaires à ce Philosophe ne peuvent servir qu'à exprimer confusément aux sens et à l'imagination les sentimens confus que l'on a des choses sensibles: ou à faire parler d'une manière si vague et si indéterminée, que l'on n'exprime rien de distinct. Presque tous ses ouvrages, mais principalement ses huit Livres de Physique ... ne sont qu, une pure Logique.

concepts one can easily explain all things without knowledge of the things themselves.²²

“One becomes no wiser by hearing the Aristotelians say that fire melts metals because it has the faculty of melting, or that someone cannot digest because his stomach has not the faculty, and so on.²³” “But what is the most dangerous thing about these philosophical turns of phrase — quality, faculty, substantiality, and the like — is nevertheless this, that one is thereby ensnared in the imagining that things themselves should contain the true and original causes of the effects we see before our eyes.”

“It is a sinful error; for if there are in things themselves real causes, real faculties to act of themselves, then there is in things something divine, and we come then, just as the heathens, to deify nature.²⁴”

“It is difficult to believe that one ought neither to fear nor to love the real powers, the beings that can act upon us, that can punish us with pain and reward us with joy. And since true worship consists in love and fear, it is furthermore difficult to believe that one ought not to worship them.”

“Everything that can act upon us as a true and real cause is necessarily exalted above us (*est nécessairement au dessus de nous*). When, therefore, God in Holy Scripture proves to the Israelites that they ought to worship him — that is, that they ought to fear and love him — the most important grounds he adduces are drawn from his power to reward them and punish them. He wills that they should honour him, since it is he alone who is the true cause of good and evil; and since, according to the Prophet's word, no evil happens in their city without its being he (Jehovah) who does it.

“The natural causes are therefore by no means real causes of the evil they seem to inflict upon us, since it is God alone who works in them, he alone whom we ought to fear and love: *Soli Deo honor et gloria*.”

If this is not theological, truly theological, then what is theological?

²²S. 386. Aristote est celui qui en a le plus fait usage, tous ses Livres en sont pleins, et il y en a quelques uns, qui ne sont que pure Logique. Il propose et résout toutes choses par ces beaux mots de *genre*, d'*espece*, d'*acte*, de *puissance*, de *nature*, de *forme*, de *facultez*, de *qualitez*, de *cause par soi*, de *cause par accident*. Ses sectateurs ont de la peine à comprendre que ces mots ne signifient rien ...

²³S. 386. Le feu échauffe, sèche, durcit, et amollit, parce qu'il a la faculté de produire ces effets. Le sené purge par sa qualité purgative, le pain même nourrit, si on le veut, par sa qualité nutritive ... Telles ou semblables manières de parler ne sont point fausses, mais c'est qu'en effet elles ne signifient rien.

²⁴S. 387. Que si l'on vient ensuite à considerer attentivement l'idée que l'on a de cause ou de puissance d'agir, on ne peut douter que cette idée ne represente quelque chose de divin. Car l'idée d'une puissance souveraine est l'idée de la souveraine divinité, et l'idée d'une puissance subalterne est l'idée d'une divinité inférieure, mais d'une véritable divinité, au moins, selon la pensée des Payens, supposé que ce soit l'idée d'une puissance ou d'une cause véritable. On admet donc quelque chose de divin dans tous les corps qui nous environnent, lorsqu'on admet des formes des facultez, des qualitez, des vertus, et des êtres réels capables de produire certains effets par la force de leur nature, et l'on entre ainsi insensiblement dans le sentiment des Payens par le respect que l'on a pour leur Philosophie. Il est vrai que la foi nous redresse, mais peut-être que l'on peut dire, que si le coeur est chrétien, le fond de l'esprit est Payen.

“If we assume,” it says further, “the philosophers’ false opinion (cette fausse opinion des Philosophes), namely, that the bodies surrounding us are real causes of the joys and evils we feel, then reason seems to justify a religion like that of the heathens, and to sanction a universal corruption of morals (déreglement universel des meurs).”

“Even if reason does not directly tell us that we should therefore straightway worship onions and leeks, it nevertheless advises us to render them a certain veneration in proportion to the benefit they can render us.²⁵”

Inwardly outraged at the falsity in so wretched a philosophy (de la fausseté de cette misérable Philosophie), Malebranche then develops the doctrine: *that there is only one true cause, since there is only one true God; that nature, or the force of things, is nothing other than God’s will; that natural things are not true causes, but solely occasional causes (des causes occasionelles).*

²⁵S. 388. Il est vrai que la raison n’enseigne pas qu’il faille adorer les oignons et les porreaux par exemple, comme la souveraine divinité, parce qu’ils ne peuvent nous rendre entièrement heureux, lorsque nous en avons, ou entièrement malheureux lors que nous n’en avons point ... Mais (S. 389), si l’on ne doit pas rendre un honneur souverain aux porreaux et aux oignons, on peut toujours leur rendre quelque adoration particulière: je veux dire, qu’on peut y penser et les aimer en quelque manière, s’il est vrai qu’ils puissent en quelque sorte nous rendre heureux: on doit leur rendre honneur à proportion du bien qu’ils peuvent faire.